Whether the Muslims are Correct for Making Gentiles Follow So Many Jewish Practices (DRAFT)

In this document is given an abridged argument that when the Protestant methodology is used (i.e., having skepticism of clerical authority), the popular notion that Christians can disobey so many Mosaic laws does not meet a very high burden of proof, even if the authority of Pauline doctrine is upheld. Therefore, it is claimed herein that the Muslims are correct for implementing many Jewish practices among gentiles, such as avoidance of pork, circumcision of boys, & executing adulterers by pelting stones. It is hoped that this discussion could help change the perception of Islamic Law such that, rather than as only an expansionist military ideology, Islam is also seen as a sincere effort to restore many of the Jewish or Mosaic characteristics back to gentile Abrahamic Faith.

I recently noticed that Matthew 10:24, Luke 6:40, John 13:16, John 15:20, & 2 Peter 3:16 could serve as a special exegetical key that would force a restrained interpretation of any Pauline doctrine. Moreover, in order to avoid a major contradiction with Acts ch. 16 & 21, Pauline doctrine has to be interpreted as somewhat Judaizing, or *Pronomian* (i.e., favoring obedience to Torah, from *pro-* "in favor of" + Greek *nómos*/νόμος "[Mosaic] Law"). The words of Paul cannot simply be recognized as verbatim dictations to Paul by Christ serving as angel either. E.g., Paul acknowledges in 1 Corinthians 1:16 that he forgot whether he baptized anyone other than Crispus, Gaius, and the household of Stephanas.

In order to avoid a major contradiction with Matthew 10:24, Luke 6:40, John 13:16, John 15:20, which teach that a servant is not greater than his master, any doctrine extracted from Paul cannot be so interpreted as to overshadow the teachings by Paul's superiors about the same topics.

> (Matthew 10:24 KJV) The disciple is not above *his* master, nor the servant above his lord.
> (Luke 6:40 KJV) The disciple is not above his master: but every one that is perfect shall be as his master.
> (John 13:16 KJV) Verily, verily, I say unto you, The servant is not greater than his lord; neither he that is sent greater than he that sent him.
> (John 15:20 KJV) Remember the word that I said unto you, The servant is not greater than his lord. If they have persecuted me, they will also persecute you; if they have kept my saying, they will keep yours also.

2 Peter 3:15-17 warns that Paul's writings can be difficult to understand and misused.

> (2 Peter 3:15-17 ESV) 15 And count the patience of our Lord as salvation, just as our beloved brother Paul also wrote to you according to the wisdom given him, 16 as he does in all his letters when he speaks in them of these matters. There are some things in them that are hard to understand, which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other Scriptures. 17 You therefore, beloved, knowing this beforehand, take care that you are not carried away with the error of lawless people and lose your own stability.

Therefore, any doctrine extracted from Paul must always be compared to the teachings by Paul's superiors about the same topics and tested whether it heeds the warning of 2 Peter 3:16. If Paul's teachings seem to

overshadow those of his superiors, then it would be that one is not properly heeding the warning, and so the Pauline doctrine has to be reinterpreted such as to be constrained by his superiors' teachings. This then leads to a major obstacle for doctrines such as *Sola-Fides* "Faith Alone [for Salvation]", which is popular among Protestants. However, for the topic at hand, there is no need to immediately challenge the doctrine of *Sola-Fides.*

Even the adherents of *Sola-Fides* would say that Christians do not have permission to sin even when granted the Gift of God's Grace for Salvation by Faith alone. What remains then is the question of how many Mosaic laws are still relevant to define sin. Even among mainstream Christians (i.e., Catholic, Orthodox, & the most popular Protestant denominations), transgression against some Mosaic laws such as those against adultery, bearing false witness, murder, and theft (Exodus 20:13-16) count as sin. Therefore, even according to mainstream Christians, verses from Paul's letters which seem at first glance to be dissuading obedience to Mosaic Law cannot be interpreted as dissuading every Mosaic law's implementation. E.g.,

> (Ephesians 2:8-9 ESV) 8 For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, 9 not a result of works, so that no one may boast.
> (Galatians 2:16 ESV) yet we know that a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ, so we also have believed in Christ Jesus, in order to be justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law, because by works of the law no one will be justified.
> (Romans 7:6 ESV) But now we are released from the law, having died to that which held us captive, so that we serve in the new way of the Spirit and not in the old way of the written code.

Verses such as these, even according to the adherents of *Sola-Fides,* cannot be interpreted as dissuading all works of the law; at least some works of the law such as loving one's neighbor (Leviticus 19:18) and honoring one's parents (Exodus 20:12) still are in effect even when saved by Faith alone. The general mantra is that even though one is saved by Faith, Salvation by Faith does not abolish the need for obedience. Paul is not teaching against works of the Law per-se, but against a transactional understanding of works of the Law -- against the notion that one's good works can be exchanged like currency for Salvation. By teaching this, Paul forces a shift of motivation of doing works of the Law towards non-transactional motivation.

> (Galatians 5:22-23 ESV) 22 But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law.

Here, "fruit" refers to the results or consequences. He is teaching that living by the "Spirit" naturally results in the good works of love, patience, self-control, etc. That is, Paul is attempting to purify the motivations to do good works, shifting the motivation from a transactional one towards a non-transactional one (i.e., a more altruistic motivation which he expects to naturally arise from true Faith & from living by the "Spirit"). Indeed, Paul even commands ethical principles to his audience, which would be nonsensical if he were teaching that one now has permission to disobey & to sin. E.g.,

> (Romans 12:9-16 ESV) 9 Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good. 10 Love one another with brotherly affection. Outdo one another in showing honor. 11 Do not be slothful in zeal, be fervent in spirit, serve the Lord. 12 Rejoice in hope, be patient in tribulation, be constant in prayer. 13

> Contribute to the needs of the saints and seek to show hospitality. 14 Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse them. 15 Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep. 16 Live in harmony with one another. Do not be haughty, but associate with the lowly. Never be wise in your own sight.

Having the premise that even if one is saved by Faith alone, this does not give permission to sin & to disobey important commandments, we now have to return to the question of how many Mosaic laws really are no longer relevant for Christians to define sin. As mentioned earlier in the beginning of this discussion, Paul has to be interpreted as Pronomian or somewhat Judaizing to avoid a major contradiction with Acts 16, wherein Paul circumcises Timothy, who was born to a gentile father and Jewish mother in the 2nd Temple period when Jewish identity was still mostly patrilineal instead of matrilineal. Moreover, ch. 16 occurs after ch. 15, which is when the Jerusalem Apostolic Decree takes place. The incident of Paul circumcising Timothy in Acts 16 presents an interpretative challenge of Galatians 5:2-3:

> (Galatians 5:2-3 ESV) 2 Look: I, Paul, say to you that if you accept circumcision, Christ will be of no advantage to you. 3 I testify again to every man who accepts circumcision that he is obligated to keep the whole law.

An American advocate of the doctrine of Biblical inerrancy named Norman Geisler wrote the following concerning this topic:[1]

> Acts 16:1–3—Why did Paul have Timothy circumcised when he himself spoke so strongly against it?
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> Problem: Paul's main point in Galatians can be summarized in his words, "If you become circumcised, Christ will profit you nothing" (Gal. 5:2). Yet Paul admits that he had Timothy circumcised "because of the Jews who were in that region" (Acts 16:3). Wasn't this a contradiction to his own teaching.
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> Solution: Even if Paul were wrong here in his action, it would not prove that the Bible erred in its teaching, but simply that Paul erred. Paul, like any other human being, was capable of error. Since the Bible is the Word of God (see Introduction), it is not capable of erring in anything it teaches.
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> Furthermore, Paul's action in having Timothy circumcised is not necessarily inconsistent with what he taught in Galatians, since the two cases are different. Paul was violently opposed to any who made circumcision necessary for salvation. But he never opposed it as helpful for evangelism. Indeed, Paul said elsewhere, "to the Jews I became as a Jew, that I might win Jews" (1 Cor. 9:20). However, when Judaizers insisted that "unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you cannot be saved" (Acts 15:1), then Paul took an intractable stand against circumcision.

The key sentence here is "Paul was violently opposed to any who made circumcision necessary for salvation." That is, Geisler interpreted Galatians 5:2-3 as teaching against the specific doctrine that circumcision is a requirement for Salvation, and not against circumcision per-se. Paul is known to sometimes use language that seems overreaching at first glance. E.g.,

[1] Geisler, Norman L. *When Critics Ask: A Popular Handbook on Bible Difficulties.* (SP Publications, Inc., 1992). p. 435.

(1 Corinthians 8:7-9 ESV) 7 However, not all possess this knowledge. But some, through former association with idols, eat food as really offered to an idol, and their conscience, being weak, is defiled. 8 Food will not commend us to God. We are no worse off if we do not eat, and no better off if we do. 9 But take care that this right of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block to the weak.

Here, Paul is calling it a "right" to eat meat sacrificed to idols, which seems like an overreaching statement at first glance. Another example would be him calling Christ a "curse":

(Galatians 3:13 ESV) 13 Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us—for it is written, "Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree"—

These kinds of statements, however, would have to be read more carefully in context rather than taken at face value, as warned in 2 Peter 3:16. Paul appeals to the life of Abraham to support his stance on circumcision, citing that Abraham was chosen by God for his faith even before he circumcised the males of his tribe (Romans 4:9-12); the implicit argument is that if even Abraham could be chosen as righteous servant before God prior to his circumcision, then so too should gentile Christians be exempt from the initiation requirement of circumcision to enter the Church (i.e., God's chosen community), and so too should gentile Christians be considered justified by Faith and not by the work of circumcision.

An important detail, however, is that it is said in Genesis 26:4-5 that God would assist Abraham's offspring **because** he kept the commandments, statutes, & laws that were ordered of him by God. This serves as additional evidence that justification by Faith does not give permission to disobey.

(Genesis 26:4-5 KJV, emphasis mine) 4 And I will make thy seed to multiply as the stars of heaven, and will give unto thy seed all these countries; and in thy seed shall all the nations of the earth be blessed; 5 **Because that** Abraham obeyed my voice, and kept my charge, my commandments, my statutes, and my laws.

This context could therefore inform our reading of passages such as 1 Corinthians 7:18-19, wherein it seems at first glance again that Paul is dissuading circumcision.

(1 Corinthians 7:18-19 LSB, emphasis mine) 18 Was any man called *when he was already* circumcised? He is not to become uncircumcised. Has anyone been called in uncircumcision? He is not to be circumcised. 19 Circumcision is nothing, and uncircumcision is nothing, **but *what matters is* the keeping of the commandments of God.**

Two important observations are to be made here: the 1st is that circumcision & uncircumcision are both called "nothing" here, so Paul is not favoring uncircumcision above circumcision in this context, for they are both equally "nothing" here; the 2nd is the key clause: "but *what matters is* the keeping of the commandments of God". Among the commandments of God which Paul kept are the ones of the Jewish festivals; e.g., Paul waiting for the end of the feast of unleavened bread before leaving Philippi in Acts 20:6, Paul hastening to Jerusalem for Pentecost in Acts 20:16, Paul instructing to keep the feast in 1 Corinthians 5:8. Moreover, a textual variant of

Acts 18:21 commonly found in the Byzantine Text Type recensions, which is also translated in the KJV, has Paul committed to keeping the feast in Jerusalem.

> (Acts 18:21 KJV) But bade them farewell, saying, I must by all means keep this feast that cometh in Jerusalem: but I will return again unto you, if God will. And he sailed from Ephesus.

However, in the Alexandrian Text Type tradition, to which belong the Codex Vaticanus, Codex Sinaiticus, and P66 manuscript, the clause in Acts 18:21 about attending the feast in Jerusalem is absent, which is why this portion is excised in many modern translations.

Having the premise that Paul was still devoted to the Jewish festivals, a proposition then naturally arises to explain why Paul circumcised Timothy: namely, it was to comply with Exodus 12:48 so that Timothy could fully observe Passover with the Jews he was ministering to.

> (Exodus 12:48 KJV) And when a stranger shall sojourn with thee, and will keep the passover to the LORD, let all his males be circumcised, and then let him come near and keep it; and he shall be as one that is born in the land: for no uncircumcised person shall eat thereof.

Timothy, having a gentile father during a time when Jewish identity was largely patrilineal instead of the later matrilineality, would be classified as a sojourner among the Israelites, and therefore still has to be circumcised to fully observe Passover. Paul was not against circumcision per-se, but against the doctrine that circumcision ought to be an initiation requirement for entrance into God's community for Salvation.

The Hanafi school of Islamic Law, which is the largest school of Islamic Law, and the Maliki school of Islamic Law, which is the most popular in North Africa outside Somalia & Egypt, both classify the act of circumcision of new adult male converts as *Sunnah Mu'akkadah* (سنّة مؤكدة) which means to be highly recommended, but not absolutely required (e.g., Ibn Abi Zayd Al-Qayrawani's *Risalah* 29.9a). Their circumcision policies of new adult male converts would therefore be quite similar to that of a pronomian interpretation of Paul.

Whether Jesus Relaxed the Mosaic Death Penalty Laws

The story of Jesus and the adulteress in John 8 is often cited as evidence that Jesus intended to relax Mosaic death penalty laws, but this story is most likely a forgery, for it is absent in early manuscripts of the Gospel of John such as the Codex Sinaiticus, the Codex Vaticanus, and the P66 manuscript. However, even if this story is authentic, it still is not strong enough evidence that Jesus intended to relax Mosaic death penalty laws.

> (John 8:3-11 ESV) 3 The scribes and the Pharisees brought a woman who had been caught in adultery, and placing her in the midst 4 they said to him, "Teacher, this woman has been caught in the act of adultery. 5 Now in the Law, Moses commanded us to stone such women. So what do you say?" 6 This they said to test him, that they might have some charge to bring against him. Jesus bent down and wrote with his finger on the ground. 7 And as they continued to ask him, he stood up and said to them, "Let him who is without sin among you be the first to throw a stone at her." 8 And once more he bent down and wrote on the ground. 9 But when they heard it, they went away one by one, beginning with the older ones, and Jesus was left alone with the woman standing before him. 10 Jesus stood up and said to her,

"Woman, where are they? Has no one condemned you?" 11 She said, "No one, Lord." And Jesus said, "Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more."]]

After a more careful reading of verses 10-11, a major obstacle is found for the interpretation that Jesus intended to abolish the death penalty for adultery in this story. Recall that in Mosaic Law, the male adulterer has to be executed along with the female one even if he is unmarried while the female adulterer is married or betrothed (Leviticus 20:10, Deuteronomy 22:22, Deuteronomy 22:23-24) provided that the burden of proof of two or three credible witnesses is met (Deuteronomy 17:6). Verses 10-11 then offer the possibility that Jesus was only objecting to a procedural mistake, rather than trying to abolish the death penalty for adultery. Notice that the male adulterer is not present at the execution ground; and also that Jesus asks, "Has no one condemned you?", and then when the woman replies in the negative, he lets her leave. With the information at hand, the alternative explanation cannot be dismissed: namely that Jesus was not trying to abolish any Mosaic death penalty law, and was only objecting to the procedural mistakes of not bringing the male adulterer to the execution ground & not meeting the burden of proof of witnesses.

Evidence of Jesus even favoring Mosaic death penalty laws could be found in Matthew 15. A group of Pharisees criticize the followers of Jesus for not washing their hands before eating, and then Jesus criticizes this group of Pharisees for prioritizing the law of washing hands, which is an innovated law (negative connotation of 'innovate'), instead of prioritizing the established Mosaic laws of executing children that revile their parents (Exodus 21:15, 17; Leviticus 20:9).

(Matthew 15:3-8 ESV) 3 He answered them, "And why do you break the commandment of God for the sake of your tradition? 4 For God commanded, 'Honor your father and your mother,' and, 'Whoever reviles father or mother must surely die.' 5 But you say, 'If anyone tells his father or his mother, "What you would have gained from me is given to God," 6 he need not honor his father.' So for the sake of your tradition you have made void the word of God. 7 You hypocrites! Well did Isaiah prophesy of you, when he said: 8 "'This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me; 9 in vain do they worship me, teaching as doctrines the commandments of men.'"

I've also encountered Christians who say that Jesus was only promoting the law of obeying parents and was not promoting the death penalty portion of this law. However, v. 4 very plainly mentions the death penalty portion of these laws as authentic legislation from God.

(Matthew 15:4 ESV, emphasis mine) **For God commanded**, 'Honor your father and your mother,' **and, 'Whoever reviles father or mother must surely die.'**

We cannot assume beforehand that Jesus conformed to all the ethical standards of what would later be favored by modern First World societies. After all, in an ancient Jewish context, sinlessness would include perfect obedience to Mosaic Law. There was no such thing as a New Testament (abbr. NT) canon during the earliest years of Christianity. The so-called "Bible" at this time among the earliest Christians was just simply the Old Testament (abbr. OT) and whatever oral traditions of Jesus were in circulation & accessible to them. The OT repeatedly commands obedience to Mosaic Law and calls the Torah wisdom, guidance, light, & source of joy. E.g.,

(Psalm 1:1-2 ESV) 1 Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers; 2 but his delight is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he meditates day and night.

With such a context, it is expected that sinlessness would include perfect obedience to Mosaic Law. That is, in order to assert that Jesus was sinless in an ancient Jewish context, it must be asserted that he interpreted & obeyed the Law of Moses impeccably, living a perfectly Kosher life as the perfect Jewish rabbi. It was not according to our modern First World values that Jesus was sinless, but according to the standards of Torah. C.f.,

(Luke 1:5-6 KJV, emphasis mine) 5 There was in the days of Herod, the king of Judaea, a certain priest named Zacharias, of the course of Abia: and his wife *was* of the daughters of Aaron, and her name *was* Elisabeth. 6 And they were both righteous before God, **walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless.**

Whether Jesus Abolished Kashrut Food Laws

The story in Matthew 15:1-9 is also told in Mark 7:1-13, but modern translators often interpret Mark 7:19 as Jesus declaring all foods clean.

[Mark 7:18-19 ESV] 18 And he said to them, "Then are you also without understanding? Do you not see that whatever goes into a person from outside cannot defile him, 19 since it enters not his heart but his stomach, and is expelled?" (Thus he declared all foods clean.)

This interpretation by modern translators is often used to claim that Jesus abolished all the Kashrut food laws. Recall, however, that the original text did not have quotation marks, nor most of the punctuation marks, nor distinct sets of capital & lowercase letters. What is translated to "Thus he declared all foods clean" is a participle phrase without an explicit subject in the Greek text: καθαρίζων πάντα τὰ βρώματα. It is no less plausible that the doer of this participle phrase is actually the digestive process, of food entering into the stomach and then exiting the body. E.g., the KJV renders verse 19 as follows:

(Mark 7:19 KJV) Because it entereth not into his heart, but into the belly, and goeth out into the draught, purging all meats?

Recall that in older varieties of English, the word 'meat' often just means food in general, and not necessarily animal flesh specifically. A variation of this teaching is also told in Matthew 15, favoring an interpretation of which Jesus does not abolish Kashrut food laws, but is only making a point that eating with unwashed hands does not defile a person. After all, the immediate context of this teaching is the debate about the innovated hand-washing law.

(Matthew 15:16-20 ESV) 16 And he said, "Are you also still without understanding? 17 Do you not see that whatever goes into the mouth passes into the stomach and is expelled? 18 But what comes out of the mouth proceeds from the heart, and this defiles a person. 19 For out of the heart come evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, theft, false witness, slander. 20 These are what defile a person. But to eat with unwashed hands does not defile anyone."

A story is also told in Acts 10 of Peter having a vision of a blanket holding different kinds of animals floating towards him, and being instructed to eat by a voice from heaven.

> (Acts 10:11-17 ESV, emphases mine) 11 and saw the heavens opened and something like a great sheet descending, being let down by its four corners upon the earth. 12 In it were all kinds of animals and reptiles and birds of the air. 13 And there came a voice to him: "Rise, Peter; kill and eat." 14 But Peter said, "**By no means, Lord; for I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean.**" 15 And the voice came to him again a second time, "What God has made clean, do not call common." 16 This happened three times, and the thing was taken up at once to heaven. 17 **Now while Peter was inwardly perplexed as to what the vision that he had seen might mean**, behold, the men who were sent by Cornelius, having made inquiry for Simon's house, stood at the gate

Could this story be used to abolish Kashrut food laws? Two important observations are to be made here: the 1st is the portion "By no means, Lord; for I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean" which implies that Peter continued to obey Mosaic dietary restrictions even after the Ascension of Christ, and therefore did not interpret Jesus' teaching in Matthew 15 & Mark 7 as an abolition of Kashrut; the 2nd observation to be made here is the portion "Now while Peter was inwardly perplexed as to what the vision that he had seen might mean" which implies that Peter did not immediately understand the meaning of this vision, and had to ponder its meaning afterwards. Later in v. 28 he gives an interpretation of the vision after some pondering.

> (Acts 10:28 ESV) And he said to them, "You yourselves know how unlawful it is for a Jew to associate with or to visit anyone of another nation, but God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean.

That is, he interpreted the animals in that vision as representing gentile people, and that he is instructed to not call any gentile person common or unclean. It would seem that the practice of considering gentiles common/unclean was an innovated law instead of an authentic Mosaic law. Peter gave another commentary of the vision in ch. 11:

> (Acts 11:1-12 ESV, emphases mine) 1 Now the apostles and the brothers who were throughout Judea heard that the Gentiles also had received the word of God. 2 So when Peter went up to Jerusalem, **the circumcision party criticized him, saying,** 3 **"You went to uncircumcised men and ate with them."** 4 But Peter began and explained it to them in order: 5 "I was in the city of Joppa praying, and in a trance I saw a vision, something like a great sheet descending,...
> ...9 But the voice answered a second time from heaven, 'What God has made clean, do not call common.' 10 This happened three times, and all was drawn up again into heaven. 11 And behold, at that very moment three men arrived at the house in which we were, sent to me from Caesarea. 12 **And the Spirit told me to go with them, making no distinction**. These six brothers also accompanied me, and we entered the man's house.

The first sentence of verse 12 very closely resembles the interpretation by Peter given in Acts 10:28, and this was told in the context of a response to the criticism in verses 2-3, of which Peter is criticized for eating with uncircumcised men. Notice that nowhere in this chapter does Peter say that Kashrut food laws have been

abolished. Peter interpreted the vision of the blanket of animals as concerning whether gentiles could be called common or unclean, not about the clean or unclean status of food.

Whether Christ Abolished Sabbath Obligations

In the Gospel accounts, Jesus is depicted as relaxing some Sabbath restrictions, such as allowing the plucking of grain casually to eat & the healing of the sick on Sabbath (e.g., Matthew 12:1, Mark 21:23, Luke 6:1, Matthew 12:10-13, Luke 6:6-10, Luke 13:10-15, Luke 14:2-5, John 5:9, John 9:14). These, however, are not to be interpreted as a complete abolition of the Sabbath, since Mary Magdalene and the other women who visit the Holy Sepulchre after the Crucifixion wait until Sunday, implying that they do not interpret Christ as abolishing the Sabbath. Not only this, but they do not even interpret the Crucifixion as an event that would end the need for Sabbath compliance.

Instead, Christ was teaching something akin to the legal principle of *Piquaḥ Nephesh* (פיקוח נפש) "saving a life", which is the principle that parts of Mosaic Law could be broken for the sake of a higher ethical priority during emergency. The permission to pluck grain in Matthew 12:1 and Luke 6:1 seems to also conform to *Piquaḥ Nephesh*, since it was probably done to avoid fainting from hunger. Indeed, Christ also criticized the hypocrisy of the scholars that opposed him, mentioning that for them, livestock falling into a pit was a great enough emergency to break the restrictions against carrying heavy objects outside.

> (Matthew 12:11-12 LSB) 11 And He said to them, "What man is there among you who has a sheep, and if it falls into a pit on the Sabbath, will not take hold of it and lift it out? 12 How much more valuable then is a man than a sheep! So then, it is lawful to do good on the Sabbath."

Jesus is therefore not teaching against the Sabbath per-se, but against the excessive Sabbath restrictions imposed by misguided scholars that prohibited even the treatment of medical emergencies on Sabbath. The principle of *Piquaḥ Nephesh* is also implemented in post-2nd-Temple Judaism.

Whether Christ Abolished the Right to Divorce

Christ is depicted as teaching against divorce in Mark 10:9-12 & Luke 16:18.

> (Luke 16:18 KJV) Whosoever putteth away his wife, and marrieth another, committeth adultery: and whosoever marrieth *her* that is put away from her husband committeth adultery.

Which seems, at first glance, to be in direct opposition to the Torah law allowing divorce:

> (Deuteronomy 24:1 KJV) When a man hath taken a wife, and married her, and it come to pass that she find no favour in his eyes, because he hath found some uncleanness in her: then let him write her a bill of divorcement, and give *it* in her hand, and send her out of his house.

However, this legal ruling made by Jesus has a slight variation in Matthew, giving a condition in which it is permissible to divorce:

(Matthew 19:9 KJV, emphasis mine) And I say unto you, Whosoever shall put away his wife, **except *it be* for fornication,** and shall marry another, committeth adultery: and whoso marrieth her which is put away doth commit adultery.

Indeed, Deuteronomy 24:1 gives a condition of when divorce is permissible, namely the portion "and it come to pass that she find no favour in his eyes, because he hath found some uncleanness in her". Jesus' legal ruling could also be read in the context of Malachi 2:16, in which it is said that God frowns up divorce, so this teaching also has precedent in OT teachings.

(Malachi 2:16 ESV) **"For the man who does not love his wife but divorces her, says the Lord, the God of Israel, covers his garment with violence, says the Lord of hosts.** So guard yourselves in your spirit, and do not be faithless.

Jesus' ruling could also be read in the context of the historical debate had around the 1st century BC or 1st century AD between the schools of Rabbi Hillel and Rabbi Shammai, documented in Gittin 90a of the Talmud concerning the acceptable circumstances of divorce, and therefore the precise interpretation of the bounds of Deuteronomy 24:1. The school of Rabbi Hillel allowed for lenient conditions of when divorce is permissible, even for minor reasons such as the wife burning a dish; whereas the school of Rabbi Shammai demanded stricter conditions for divorce to be allowed, pretty much only when forbidden sexual relations are involved. The Gospel of Matthew seems to intentionally portray Jesus as a Jewish legal scholar, situating Jesus in the context of this legal debate, and presenting Jesus as favoring the interpretation by the school of Rabbi Shammai.

The "Ye have heard... But I say..." Statements

In Matthew 5 there are six instances of Jesus mentioning a Jewish Law, but then saying "But I say unto you" followed by a different commandment.

(Matthew 5:21-22 KJV) 21 Ye have heard that it was said of them of old time, Thou shalt not kill; and whosoever shall kill shall be in danger of the judgment: 22 But I say unto you, That whosoever is angry with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment: and whosoever shall say to his brother, Raca, shall be in danger of the council: but whosoever shall say, Thou fool, shall be in danger of hell fire.

(Matthew 5:27-28 KJV) 27 Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not commit adultery: 28 But I say unto you, That whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart.

(Matthew 5:33-37 KJV) 33 Again, ye have heard that it hath been said by them of old time, Thou shalt not forswear thyself, but shalt perform unto the Lord thine oaths: 34 But I say unto you, Swear not at all; neither by heaven; for it is God's throne: 35 Nor by the earth; for it is his footstool: neither by Jerusalem; for it is the city of the great King. 36 Neither shalt thou swear by thy head, because thou canst not make one hair white or black. 37 But let your communication be, Yea, yea; Nay, nay: for whatsoever is more than these cometh of evil.

(Matthew 5:38-39 KJV) 38 Ye have heard that it hath been said, An eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth: 39 But I say unto you, That ye resist not evil: but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also.
(Matthew 5:43-44 KJV) 43 Ye have heard that it hath been said, Thou shalt love thy neighbour, and hate thine enemy. 44 But I say unto you, Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you;

The teaching against divorce is mentioned in this chapter as well:

(Matthew 5:31-32 KJV) 31 It hath been said, Whosoever shall put away his wife, let him give her a writing of divorcement: 32 But I say unto you, That whosoever shall put away his wife, saving for the cause of fornication, causeth her to commit adultery: and whosoever shall marry her that is divorced committeth adultery.

Of these six items, all but the one about divorce could be understood as supererogatory versions of the old laws. That is, don't even build up the motivation to murder; don't even build up the anger that could lead to the motivation to murder; don't even build up the motivation to fornicate by looking at a woman lustfully; commit oneself to doing something even after a simple reply of 'yes' without a formal promise to do it; not only should one love his neighbor, but even love his enemies, etc. That is, Jesus is teaching to go above & beyond what is required to comply with these laws. Though it might not be apparent at first glance, here is also taught supererogatory versions of *lex talionis* (i.e., eye for eye, tooth for tooth) legislated in Deuteronomy 19:21, Leviticus 24:20; this is because *lex talionis* is intended to serve two main purposes:

1. Deter injury done to another. E.g., by fearing the possible harm done to one's own body, a person is then reluctant to harm the body parts of another. Jesus already teaches a supererogatory commandment for this objective in Matthew 5:21-22 by teaching against anger without cause, which would otherwise serve as motivation to do harm to another.
2. Prevent excessive retaliation. When the injured party has more resources or power than the injuring party, the injured party could sometimes be motivated to retaliate excessively, doing more harm to the injuring party than what was done to the injured party. *Lex talionis* is therefore setting a maximum limit of how severe the retaliation is allowed. When Jesus teaches to turn the other cheek, he is teaching a supererogatory commandment for this 2nd objective. That is, don't even retaliate at all, let alone go beyond the maximum limit of how much retaliation is allowed.

Jesus is therefore not teaching a different ethical system to replace Mosaic Law, but a supererogatory version of a portion of Mosaic Law in these commandments. The last two non-marital ones complement the first item, teaching a non-aggression principle, which does also have precedent in the OT.

(Proverbs 3:31 ESV) Do not contend with a man for no reason, when he has done you no harm. Do not envy a man of violence and do not choose any of his ways,

Even the teaching of loving thy enemies has precedence in the Torah. E.g., Abraham is depicted in Genesis 18 as showing concern for the inhabitants of Sodom and Gomorrah, even though they were polytheists with

abominable moral standards. Abraham went so far as to haggle with God, to lower the threshold of the number of righteous people in the city for God to show mercy.

Pronomian Portrayal of Jesus in the Gospel of Matthew

The Gospel of Matthew very plainly depicts Jesus as favoring obedience to Mosaic Law. E.g.,

> (Matthew 5:17-18 ESV) 17 "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them. 18 For truly, I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota, not a dot, will pass from the Law until all is accomplished.

In my experience, it is common for mainstream Christians to interpret "fulfilling the Law" as also ending the need to obey the Law. But why is it less plausible for the phrase "fulfilling the Law" to mean obeying the Law perfectly without terminating the need to obey the Law after "fulfillment"? The plain meaning of "not abolish the law" is to keep this law binding, so why does the meaning of ending obligations to obey the Law have to be inserted? As mentioned earlier, sinlessness in an ancient Jewish context would include perfect obedience to Mosaic Law, so a better interpretation of "fulfillment" is to exclude termination of the need to obey the law, but to have fulfillment of prophecy & fulfillment of the requirements of the Law by perfect obedience to the Law.

> (Matthew 5:19 ESV) Therefore whoever relaxes one of the least of these commandments and teaches others to do the same will be called least in the kingdom of heaven, but whoever does them and teaches them will be called great in the kingdom of heaven.

The plain meaning of verses such as Matthew 5:19 is that it is good to make others obey the Law of Moses, and it is not good to make others stop obeying laws in the Torah. Even if hyperbolic, the basic idea is that one ought to obey lots of Mosaic laws. Here is where we can make use of our special interpretative key mentioned in the beginning: in order to avoid a major contradiction with Matthew 10:24, Luke 6:40, John 13:16, John 15:20, & 2 Peter 3:16, and recognizing that Paul's words cannot simply be recognized as verbatim dictations from Jesus serving as an angel, Matthew serves as another reason why Paul cannot be interpreted as dissuading obedience to Torah. Therefore, verses such as Romans 7:7 & 3:31 have to be given special emphasis when reading Paul.

> (Romans 7:7 ESV) What then shall we say? That the law is sin? By no means! Yet if it had not been for the law, I would not have known sin. For I would not have known what it is to covet if the law had not said, "You shall not covet."
> (Romans 3:31 ESV) Do we then overthrow the law by this faith? By no means! On the contrary, we uphold the law.

In Matthew 23:23, Jesus teaches to prioritize judgment, mercy, and faith as weightier matters of the Law, but a key clause is "and not to leave the other undone", implying that Jesus is **Not** giving permission to disobey other parts of the Law.

> (Matthew 23:23 KJV, emphasis mine) Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have omitted the *weightier* matters of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, **and not to leave the other undone.**

When Jesus commands the proselytizing mission to the gentiles, he orders that "all things" which he taught to his followers be taught to the gentiles.

> (Matthew 28:19-20 KJV, emphasis mine) 19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: 20 **Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you:** and, lo, I am with you alway, *even* unto the end of the world. Amen.

When combined with the overall pronomian portrayal of Christ in the Gospel of Matthew, and with the absence of any simplified set of commandments legislated by Jesus in the Gospel of Matthew for the gentiles, the most natural candidate for the interpretation of "Teaching them to observe **all things** whatsoever I have commanded you" is that Jesus commands obedience to Mosaic Law among gentile Christians as well. C.f.,

> (Isaiah 2:3, emphasis mine) and many peoples shall come, and say: "Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD, to the house of the God of Jacob, that he may teach us his ways and that we may walk in his paths." **For out of Zion shall go forth the law**, and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.

Constraints on Paul by James as Well

Likewise, with our special interpretative key mentioned in the beginning, any doctrine extracted from Paul would have to be constrained by the teachings in the Epistle of James (attributed to James the brother of Christ) as well, if this epistle is to be held as authentic. Lest it lead to a major contradiction with Matthew 10:24, Luke 6:40, John 13:16, John 15:20, & 2 Peter 3:16, since James was a superior to Paul.

> (James 2:10 KJV) For whosoever shall keep the whole law, and yet offend in one point, he is guilty of all.
> (James 2:20-26 KJV) 20 But wilt thou know, O vain man, that faith without works is dead? 21 Was not Abraham our father justified by works, when he had offered Isaac his son upon the altar? 22 Seest thou how faith wrought with his works, and by works was faith made perfect? 23 And the scripture was fulfilled which saith, Abraham believed God, and it was imputed unto him for righteousness: and he was called the Friend of God. 24 Ye see then how that by works a man is justified, and not by faith only. 25 Likewise also was not Rahab the harlot justified by works, when she had received the messengers, and had sent *them* out another way? 26 For as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead also.

It's not too hard to see that the doctrine of *Sola-Fides* might be threatened by James. Indeed, Hegesippus (c. 107 AD - c. 180) described James as a very strict, observant Jew, who was regarded even by the other Jews as so obedient to the Torah that there was even a lair of the Jerusalem temple which only he could enter.

> (Hegesippus, *Commentaries on the Acts of the Apostles*, a fragment of Book V, tr. Alexander Roberts) James, the Lord's brother, succeeds to the government of the Church, in conjunction with the apostles. He has been universally called *the Just*, from the days of the Lord down to the present time. For many bore the name of James; but this one was holy from his mother's womb. He drank no wine or *other* intoxicating liquor, nor did he eat flesh; no razor came upon his head; he did not anoint himself with oil, nor make use of the bath. **He alone was permitted to enter the holy place**: for he did not wear any woollen garment, but fine *linen only*. He alone, *I say*, was wont to go into the temple: and he used to be

> found kneeling on his knees, begging forgiveness for the people-so that the skin of his knees became horny like that of a camel's, by reason of his constantly bending the knee in adoration to God, and begging forgiveness for the people. Therefore, in consequence of his pre-eminent justice, he was called *the Just*, and *Oblias*, which signifies in Greek *Defence of the People*, and Justice, in accordance with what the prophets declare concerning him. [emphasis mine]

With our special interpretative key about Paul, we'd have to prioritize the teachings of James when reading about the Antioch incident of Galatians 2:11-14 as well, concerning the requirements of allowing table fellowship between gentile Christians and Jews converted to Christianity:

> (Galatians 2:11-14 ESV) 11 But when Cephas came to Antioch, I opposed him to his face, because he stood condemned. 12 For before certain men came from James, he was eating with the Gentiles; but when they came he drew back and separated himself, fearing the circumcision party. 13 And the rest of the Jews acted hypocritically along with him, so that even Barnabas was led astray by their hypocrisy. 14 But when I saw that their conduct was not in step with the truth of the gospel, I said to Cephas before them all, "If you, though a Jew, live like a Gentile and not like a Jew, how can you force the Gentiles to live like Jews?"

The famous Catholic church father St. Augustine of Hippo (354 AD - 430) sent his *Letter 28* & *Letter 40* to St. Jerome of Stridon (c. 342-347 AD - 420), expressing concern about a proposed interpretation in Jerome's commentary of Galatians about this Antioch incident. Jerome had proposed that Paul & Peter, for the sake of demonstrating a lesson, were just pretending to have a disagreement, imitating a Greco-Roman practice of mock debates. Augustine was distressed at this interpretation, because it opens the possibility that other events in the Bible might also just be pretense. Therefore, Augustine asked for a method from Jerome of distinguishing between pretense and genuine events in the Bible, and proposed that the Antioch incident and Paul's devotion to Torah depicted in other parts of the NT were not pretense.

St. Jerome in his *Letter 71* said that his proposed interpretation had precedence in the scholarship of Origen, and even criticized Augustine's proposal, which he said would vindicate the pronomianism of the Ebionites & Cerinthians, which were two non-Pauline sects of early Christianity deemed heretical. Augustine in his *Letter 82* suggested that the Torah was still binding on the Jews who converted to Christianity for a time even after the Ascension of Christ, and that the Galatians 2:11-14 incident happened during this time. Augustine's proposed interpretation was controversial because Christian Supersessionist theology (i.e., the doctrine that the Mosaic covenant was replaced by non-pronomian Christianity, even among Jews who convert to Christianity) was historically very common among gentile Christians, including this time around 400 AD. Augustine & Jerome, after this written debate, agreed to set the debate aside, resume friendlier relations and, sadly, Christian Supersessionist theology was allowed to remain prevalent among gentile Christians despite this analysis of Galatians 2:11-14.

Acts 21 Incident

As explained earlier, Paul cannot be interpreted as giving permission to sin & to disobey important commandments, even if *Sola-Fides* is upheld; what then remains is the question of how many Mosaic laws really are no longer relevant for defining sin. As mentioned in the beginning, Paul has to be interpreted as

pronomian in order to avoid a major contradiction with Acts 21, wherein Paul is accused by a crowd of Jewish converts to Christianity of teaching Jews among gentiles to stop obeying Mosaic Law. Paul is then instructed by James the brother of Jesus and the other elders to shave the heads of four Nazarites (see Numbers 6) as demonstration to the crowd that the accusations against him were incorrect; that is, as a way for Paul to demonstrate that he is still obedient to Mosaic Law.

> (Acts 21:20-26 LSB, emphases mine) 20 And when they heard it they *began* glorifying God; and they said to him, "You see, brother, how many thousands there are **among the Jews of those who have believed, and they are all zealous for the Law**; 21 and they have been told about you, that you are teaching all the Jews who are among the Gentiles to forsake Moses, telling them not to circumcise their children nor to walk according to the customs. 22 What, then, is *to be done*? They will certainly hear that you have come. 23 Therefore do this that we tell you. We have four men who are under a vow; 24 take them and purify yourself along with them, and pay their expenses so that they may shave their heads. **Then all will know that there is nothing to the things which they have been told about you, but that you yourself also walk orderly, keeping the Law.** 25 But concerning the Gentiles who have believed, we wrote, having decided that they should keep from meat sacrificed to idols and from blood and from what is strangled and from sexual immorality." 26 Then Paul took the men, and the next day, purifying himself along with them, went into the temple giving notice of the completion of the days of purification, until the sacrifice was offered for each one of them.

Four key observations are to be made here: the 1st is that the crowd of Jewish converts to Christianity are said to be zealous for the Law; the 2nd is that instead of saying the crowd is incorrect for being zealous for the Law, it is said that they are incorrect for accusing Paul of dissuading Jews among gentiles from continuing to obey Mosaic Law; the 3rd is that James & the other elders are operating under the assumption that Mosaic Law is still binding, at least among Jews that convert to Christianity; so it can be inferred that the original Christians did not interpret the teachings of Jesus as terminating the need to obey Torah, at least among Jews that convert to Christianity; the 4th observation is that Paul makes an effort to demonstrate to the crowd that he is still obedient to Mosaic Law, after being instructed to do so by James & the other elders, and was not trying to dissuade obedience to it; we also cannot just say that Paul, James, & the other elders were just pretending to show that Paul continued obedience to Mosaic Law, lest we run into the same problem Saints Augustine & Jerome had about Galatians 2:11-14.

Therefore, Christian Supersessionist theology, which unfortunately was very common among gentile Christians throughout history, severely contradicts with Acts 21. That is, Jews that convert to Christianity still have to eat Kosher, keep Sabbath, circumcise their boys, avoid menstruating wives, execute adulterers by throwing rocks at them, etc. Verse 25 seems at first glance to be teaching a dual covenant theology, that is, that the Mosaic covenant remains binding among Jewish converts to Christianity, but then gentile Christians follow a different set of laws. Of the four commandments mentioned in this verse, three are regarding dietary laws, and the remaining one is against sexual immorality. These four are repeated from the Acts 15 Apostolic Decree.

Acts 15 Apostolic Decree

The four commandments of Acts 21:25 are repeated from the decision of the Acts 15 Jerusalem conference for gentile Christians.

> (Acts 15:19-21 ESV) 19 Therefore my judgment is that we should not trouble those of the Gentiles who turn to God, 20 but should write to them to abstain from the things polluted by idols, and from sexual immorality, and from what has been strangled, and from blood. 21 For from ancient generations Moses has had in every city those who proclaim him, for he is read every Sabbath in the synagogues."

Acts 21:25 clarifies for the reader that three of these four commandments are dietary laws, so the remaining commandment against sexual immorality is the only non-dietary commandment here. The three dietary commandments are based on laws from the Torah: Exodus 34:15 is for avoiding foods sacrificed to idols; the law against eating strangled animals is a corollary of the law against consuming blood, since the blood of animals strangled to death are usually not drained properly; laws against consuming blood could be found in multiple places throughout the Torah (e.g. Genesis 9:4, Leviticus 3:17, Leviticus 7:26-27, Leviticus 17:10-14, Leviticus 19:26, Deuteronomy 12:16, Deuteronomy 12:23-25, Deuteronomy 15:23).

These four commandments, however, cannot be recognized as a total substitute of the Torah for gentiles to adhere to, since it contains only one non-dietary commandment, and therefore lacks all the commandments against murder, thievery, bearing false witness, etc. Therefore, even according to mainstream Christianity, at least some Mosaic laws outside these four must be followed. So what then is the intended meaning of "no greater burden than these" in v. 28?

> (Acts 21:28 ESV) For it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us to lay on you no greater burden than these requirements:

The immediate context is the debates that Paul and Barnabas had with certain factions of the early Church regarding the requirements of entry into the Church and of Salvation. These factions wanted circumcision and full adherence to Torah as requirements of Salvation.

> (Acts 15:1-2 KJV) 1 And certain men which came down from Judaea taught the brethren, *and said,* Except ye be circumcised after the manner of Moses, ye cannot be saved. 2 When therefore Paul and Barnabas had no small dissension and disputation with them, they determined that Paul and Barnabas, and certain other of them, should go up to Jerusalem unto the apostles and elders about this question.
> (Acts 15:5-7 KJV) 5 But there rose up certain of the sect of the Pharisees which believed, saying, That it was needful to circumcise *them,* and to command them to keep the law of Moses. 6 And the apostles and elders came together for to consider of this matter. 7 And when there had been much disputing, Peter rose up, and said unto them, Men *and* brethren, ye know how that a good while ago God made choice among us, that the Gentiles by my mouth should hear the word of the gospel, and believe.

An interpretation similar to that of Geisler's for Galatians 5:2-3 and the circumcision of Timothy in Acts 16 could reasonably be applied to Acts 21:28 as well; namely, no greater burden than those four as requirements of

initiation into the Church for Salvation. A challenge remains, however, for the interpretation of v. 10, which seems at first glance to depict Peter as regarding the Law of Moses as an unbearable yoke.

> (Acts 15:10 KJV) Now therefore why tempt ye God, to put a yoke upon the neck of the disciples, which neither our fathers nor we were able to bear?

The obstacle for interpreting Peter as regarding the Torah as unbearable yoke is that it conflicts with Deuteronomy 30:11 which, in both the Septuagint (abbr. LXX) and the more modern translations, says that the Torah is not excessive or not too burdensome.

> (Deuteronomy 30:11 LSB) "For this commandment which I am commanding you today is not too difficult for you, nor is it far from you.
> Ὅτι ἡ ἐντολὴ αὕτη ἣν ἐγὼ ἐντέλλομαί σοι σήμερον οὐχ ὑπέρογκός [*ouch hypérogkós* "not excessive", lit. "not over-swollen"] ἐστιν, οὐδὲ μακρὰν ἀπὸ σοῦ. (bracketed text mine)

And, as explained in the discussion about Acts 21, the Torah remains binding on the Jews who convert to Christianity, and Peter was a Jew. A similar description to "yoke" is also found in Matthew 23:4, which might offer clues for the proper interpretation of Peter in Acts 15:10.

> (Matthew 23:4 KJV) For they bind heavy burdens and grievous to be borne, and lay *them* on men's shoulders; but they *themselves* will not move them with one of their fingers.

It is generally thought that the "burdens" here refer to excessive rules innovated by misguided scholars among the Pharisees. E.g., the International Critical Commentary (ICC) of the NT comments the following of this verse:[2]

> The law was given not as a burden, but as a privilege. But the Pharisaic interpretation of it made it a burden upon life. And the Pharisees refused to lighten this ever accumulating burden of legal restrictions in the slightest degree. Traditionalism is always unwilling to relinquish what has become effete and antiquated. The burdens referred to are those of the traditional law with its ever-increasing complexity.

In other words, the "burdens" here refer to the Pharisaic interpretations of the Law, which accumulated many innovations or excessive legal restrictions. Indeed, the Acts 15 Jerusalem conference was in response to a group of Pharisees who had converted to Christianity mentioned in Acts 15:5. Therefore, it is not unreasonable to interpret the "yoke" spoken of by Peter in Acts 15:10 as being a similar kind of "burden" mentioned in Matthew 23:4, as being the excessive Pharisaic interpretation of Mosaic Law. Therefore, with the information at hand, it cannot be concluded that Peter was dreading the obligations of obeying Torah per-se. With the premise that Jewish converts to Christianity must obey the Torah, c.f.,

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[2] Allen, Willoughby C. *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel According to St. Matthew.* 3rd ed. (Edinburgh: T&T Clark Ltd., 1912), precise page not reported where it is digitized: https://biblehub.com/commentaries/icc/matthew/23.htm (accessed July 22, 2026).

> (1 Peter 1:15-16 ESV) 15 but as he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, 16 since it is written, "You shall be holy, for I am holy."
> (Romans 7:12 ESV, emphasis mine) So **the law is holy**, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good

The question remains, however, of how gentile Christians are supposed to know which parts of the Torah must be obeyed by gentile Christians.

Twofold & Threefold Distinction Methods

To answer the question of which Mosaic laws ought to be obeyed by gentile Christians outside the four commandments of the Acts 15 decree, a common method is to classify different Torah laws into two or three categories, such that at least one category is abrogated under the New Covenant. The twofold method usually involves dividing the laws into moral laws and a 2nd category which can be called symbolic, ritual, or ceremonial. E.g., St. Augustine had a twofold distinction in *Contra Faustum* VI.2.

An example of the threefold method, having the categories of moral, ceremonial, & judicial, can be found by the famous medieval Catholic scholar Thomas Aquinas (c. 1225 - 1274) in *Summa Theologica*, 2a, Question 99, Article 4. Another example can be found in the 1647 Westminster Confession of Faith ch. XIX § III-V, which distinguishes between moral, ceremonial, & judicial laws, such that gentile Christians have to follow only the judicial laws insofar as "general equity", and the moral laws.

Some denominations such as the traditional Orthodox Church of Egypt, called the Coptic Church, and the traditional Orthodox Church of Ethiopia & Eritrea, called the Tewahedo Church, practice circumcision, and the Tewahedo Church even retains a pork prohibition; the Seventh Day Adventist sect advocates Sabbath observance and vegetarianism, which of course avoids non-Kosher meat. Otherwise, things like dietary laws, menstrual taboos, and circumcision are usually classified as ceremonial laws by gentile Christians. The problem with the twofold & threefold distinction methods is that they are prone to having local gentile cultural norms and legal norms serve as the standard of classification, instead of having the Biblical tradition be interpreted on its own terms. E.g.,

> (Deuteronomy 22:5 KJV) The woman shall not wear that which pertaineth unto a man, neither shall a man put on a woman's garment: for all that do so *are* abomination unto the LORD thy God.

A law against cross-dressing might seem ceremonial in modern First World settings, but it is called an abomination to God in the Torah. Taboos against eating dog meat & most bugs are also common among Christians of European background, so these Mosaic dietary restrictions are de-facto observed. Moreover, it is also common among protestants to have stricter compliance with the law against graven images (Exodus 20:4), having stronger taboos against icons & statues in religious settings. Therefore, even Mosaic laws which seem to be "ceremonial" might be adhered to by gentile Christians. Therefore, the usual twofold or threefold method is very prone to subjectivity, and therefore is not the best method.

An elephant in the room is that the weaknesses of the twofold & threefold distinction methods even spill into the four commandments of the Acts 15 edict. In order to comply with the three dietary laws of the Acts 15 edict,

it is best to slaughter animals in a manner that resembles Kosher or Halal slaughter, by quickly making a deep cut to the throat of the livestock & draining the blood, while also uttering an invocation in the name of God. This kind of livestock slaughtering method, however, is barely ever practiced by gentile Christians outside Ethiopia & Eritrea. Also, what Mosaic sexual prohibitions are still relevant for defining sexual immorality among gentiles?

A popular film in the American/European cultural sphere is James Cameron's *Titanic* (1997), which depicts a woman on the Titanic named Rose engaged to an upper-class man named Caledon, but she ends up having an affair with a lower-class passenger named Jack; and Rose & Jack are depicted as protagonists while Caledon is the villain. In Mosaic ethics, Rose's affair with Jack would deserve the death penalty if the burden of proof is met (Deuteronomy 22:23), whereas something like first-cousin marriage is not prohibited at all in Mosaic Law. Whereas in our typical modern, Euro-centric social norms, there is a strong taboo against first-cousin marriage, and a movie like James Cameron's *Titanic* (1997) could gain wide popularity. Also, does failure to comply with menstrual prohibitions count as sexual immorality?

Sojourner in Israel Method

The twofold & threefold distinction methods of determining which Mosaic laws are binding on gentile Christians are prone to subjectivity, and are at the mercy of the cultural & legal norms of local gentiles when determining which Mosaic laws must be obeyed by gentile Christians, rather than defining Christian ethics on the Biblical tradition's own terms. A less subjective method would be to classify gentile Christians as *gerim* (גרים) 'sojourners/strangers' in Israel, for whom obligations are also prescribed in various parts of the Torah. After all, Paul makes the analogy that gentile Christians are like new branches grafted in with the natural branches of Israel (Romans 11:11-24), and classifying Timothy as sojourner in Israel was how we explained his circumcision earlier.

> (Leviticus 24:22 ESV) You shall have the same rule for the sojourner and for the native, for I am the LORD your God."
> (Numbers 15:15-16 ESV) 15 For the assembly, there shall be one statute for you and for the stranger who sojourns with you, a statute forever throughout your generations. You and the sojourner shall be alike before the LORD. 16 One law and one rule shall be for you and for the stranger who sojourns with you."

Including punishments:

> (Numbers 15:30-31 ESV, emphases mine) 30 But the person who does anything with a high hand, whether he is native or a sojourner, reviles the LORD, and that person shall be cut off from among his people. 31 **Because** he has despised the word of the LORD **and has broken his commandment**, that person shall be utterly cut off; his iniquity shall be on him."

Another important piece of data which cannot be ignored is how *gerim* (גרים) is translated in the LXX. One Torah scholar, Prof. Ishay Rosen-Zvi of Tel-Aviv University, wrote the following observations about the LXX's translation of *gerim* (emphases mine):[3]

> The earliest source we have to take up the problem of why the Torah uses the term *ger* in more than one sense is the Greek Septuagint (LXX), which uses two different terms to translate *ger* depending on context:
>
> - *Paroikos* (πάροικος)—The standard Greek word for "neighbor," literally "living near." LXX uses it in the sense of foreigners living outside their own country among another group, i.e., "neighbors who are not the same." It is the standard translation for *ger* when the term refers to Israelites living among foreigners, but is only rarely used for *ger* in reference to foreigners living among Israelites; it is, instead, the preferred translation of *toshav*, "sojourner" in such cases (Exod 12:45, Lev 22:10, 25:6, 23).[18]
> - *Proselytos* (προσήλυτος)—A Jewish-Greek[19] term for a *ger* that literally means "one who has arrived," **likely implying more than just "living among," but "joining."** LXX uses this term for the vast majority of cases when *ger* refers to an outsider living among Israelites.[20]
>
> The *Ger* in Deuteronomy Who Eats Carrion
> Although LXX avoided using *paroikos* for a *ger* living among Israelites, in some cases the translators felt they had no choice. An example from Deuteronomy is telling:
> דברים יד:כא לֹא תֹאכְלוּ כָל נְבֵלָה לַגֵּר אֲשֶׁר בִּשְׁעָרֶיךָ תִּתְּנֶנָּה וַאֲכָלָהּ אוֹ מָכֹר לְנָכְרִי כִּי עַם קָדוֹשׁ אַתָּה לַיהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ
> Deut 14:21 You shall not eat anything that has died a natural death; give it to the *ger* (LXX: *paroikos*) in your community to eat, or you may sell it to a foreigner. For you are a people consecrated to YHWH your God.
>
> The position of the *ger* here is liminal. On one hand, the *ger* is explicitly marked as different from the Israelites who may not eat carrion. On the other hand, the *ger* is distinguished from the *nochri*, i.e., the outsider, in that the *ger* is to be given the meat for free, while the outsider is to be charged; that is, the Israelite has social responsibility for the *ger*, but not for the *nochri*.
>
> We may deduce from the fact that the LXX translates *ger* here as *paroikos* that the translators use this term for foreigners who live among another group as a separate community, whether it is Israelites among foreigners or foreigners among Israelites. **In contrast, *proselytos* refers to foreigners who live among Israelites *and join the community and share its commandments.* This is why the same rules apply to gerim and natural citizens, because they are one legal community.**
>
> In short, LXX understands what scholars call the Priestly *ger* as **someone who has joined the Jews and is obligated to keep Jewish law**, and extends this definition to as many (non-Priestly) passages about *gerim* that can sustain it.[21]

[3] Roshen-Zvi, Ishay. "In the Torah, Is the Ger Ever a Convert?" *The Torah - com*, Published April 15, 2019, Last updated July 11, 2026 https://www.thetorah.com/article/in-the-torah-is-the-ger-ever-a-convert (accessed July 24, 2026).

To explain why this Sojourner method isn't explicitly instructed in the NT, we can continue to read what Prof. Ishay Rosen-Zvi wrote of this topic.

> The *Proselytos* and the Convert
> It is natural to assume that LXX's *proselytos* is coterminous with the Rabbinic Judaism's convert. In fact, the Greek *proselytos* (via Latin) is the source of the English word proselyte. But the matter is not so simple, and we must be wary of anachronistically translating *ger* as "convert" in the LXX because of how the rabbis eventually understood the term *ger*.[22]
>
> In fact, during the Second Temple period, **becoming a Jew did not involve crossing the sharp, binary gentile/Jew divide through a specific, legislated, instantaneous ritual that transformed the gentile into the Jew.** Instead, as Shaye Cohen meticulously shows, during this period there is a continuum, rather than a dichotomy, between various levels of identifying with and as Jews.[23]
>
> Even Josephus, at the end of the first century C.E., is still aware of this continuum, and does not describe a specific conversion ritual, **but rather the coexistence of different models to becoming a Jew**, as we see from his discussion of the conversion of King Izates of Adiabene.[24] The rabbis, however, put an end to this fluidity of identity and ritual.

Therefore, it was probably already implicitly understood among the earliest Christians that a sharp dividing line between Jew & gentile did not have to be crossed by gentiles before a gentile is considered a part of the same Jewish community under the same legal system.

Conclusions
Whether we like it or not, the most plausible conclusion is that gentile Christians also have to obey Torah like the Jews converted to Christianity. That is, besides recognizing Jesus as Messiah and having fewer rabbinic innovations, the correct version of Christianity is just regular Judaism (!), even when Pauline doctrine is upheld. And the Muslims have been correct this whole time for propagating so many Jewish practices among gentiles! The Dome of the Rock & Al-Aqsa Mosque, however, currently occupies the site of the Jerusalem temple, and Islamic Law abrogates the Temple sacrifices, so sacrifices cannot resume without evicting the Muslims from Jerusalem, which I do not advocate.

It's not difficult to explain why Islam abrogates the Temple sacrifices though. In early Christianity, there were four major sects of Pronomian Christians: the Ebionites, the Elkesaites, the Cerinthians, and the Nazarenes. The Ebionites, the Elkesaites, and the Cerinthians developed from anti-Paul factions of the Jerusalem Church, whereas the Nazarenes were moderately Pauline, interpreting Paul in a way that maintains obedience to Mosaic Law -- perhaps not too different than the arguments of this document. Whether by divine guidance or by human contrivance, Islam was made to preserve/restore many features of the Ebionite sect, including a doctrine of false pericopes (i.e., that the Bible has textual corruptions) and the abrogation of most sacrifices, which developed among the Ebionites. The doctrine of abrogating sacrifices might have had something to do with the Essene sect of late 2nd-Temple-Judaism, who opposed the sacrifices; and there are also signs in the NT that the Johannine tradition cross-references the 1QS *Community Rule* tradition of the Dead Sea Scrolls, which are often said to be associated with the Essenes.

More details about Islam's commonalities with the Ebionites, Elkesaites, Cerinthians, Nazarenes, & Essenes would be the subject of another writing, but the short answer is that Islam could be understood as somewhat of a militarized resurrection of the Ebionite sect, poised to restore Unitarian Monotheism and to propagate many Jewish practices among gentiles after the mainstream Christians had both discarded most of the Torah and standardized the doctrine of Homo-Ousionist Trinitarianism. If the knowledge had been prevalent earlier that even with Pauline doctrine, the correct version of Christianity is just regular Judaism but with Jesus as Messiah, and fewer rabbinic innovations, there probably would never had arisen Islam, since Islam seems to be a reaction (whether by divine guidance or by human contrivance) to the theological trends in mainstream Christianity. Had pronomianism prevailed, hostility towards Jews could had been less common, Christianity could had been more attractive to Jews, and a clash of civilizations between Islam & Europe might had been avoided.

I am, of course, not the first to have learned of this. As early as the 17th century, Henry Stubbe proposed that Islam has continuity with the pronomian sects in his book *An Account of the Rise and Progress of Mahometanism, and a Vindication of him and his Religion from the Calumnies of the Christians*, which was also one of the earliest books in a Christian-dominated part of Europe that speaks in defense of Islam.

> (Stubbe, *Rise and Progress of Mahometanism*, ch. I, pp. 14-15) And even Paul circumcised Timothy, tho' the son of a Gentile Father (Acts xvi. 3). Sixteen Bishops of Jerusalem were successively circumcised, saith Sulpitius Severus; and their names are mention'd by Eusebius in his *Ecclesiastical History* (l. 4. c. 5), and even those who derived their pedigree so as to shew they were of the Kindred of Christ call'd Deposyin were always of the Circumcision, as Eusebius also tells us (l. 1. 7), from hence we may frame to ourselves a prospect of the primitive Judaizing Church, since it is certain that they were zealous as to the Mosaical Law (Acts xxi. 20), and lived in a perfect conformity to the legal Rites.....
> .... They that were circumcised resorted at usual times to the public Temple Service (Acts iii. 1 & 13, 14); they paid vows, offered Sacrifices, and walked orderly, keeping the Law, & yet were believers (Acts xxi. 20, 23, 24), and there is not any sign that they were separated from the other Jews, or were accounted Hereticks upon any other account then that they held Jesus to be the Messiah & taught in his name (Acts iv. 17, 18). [sic]
> (*ibid.,* ch. VIII, pp. 145-146) Let us not then give credit to the aforesaid Stories, but ascribe another original to the Mahometical Doctrines. For my part I beleive that he was a convert to the Judaizing Christians and formed his Religion as far as possible in resemblance of theirs.....
> .... This that I have said I hope is sufficient to evince that the Religion of Mahomet is cheifly founded on the Doctrines of the Nazarene Christians and the Arrians,.... [sic]

Irish scholar John Toland in 1718 wrote *Nazarenus, or, Jewish, Gentile, and Mahometan Christianity* with similar ideas. The idea that Islam had something to do with the pronomian sects of early Christianity lie dormant until the 1861 work *Das Leben und die Lehre des Moḥammad* by Aloys Sprenger, followed up by Jules-Charles Scholl in

1874,[4] Gustav Rösch in 1876,[5] Adolf von Harnack in 1909,[6] Adolf Schlatter in 1918;[7] and since this revival there have been modern scholars studying Islam's commonalities with the Ebionites such as Hans Joachim Schoeps,[8] Patricia Crone,[9] Holger Zellentin,[10] James Tabor,[11] Jeffrey Bütz,[12] and Mustafa Akyol.[13]

In Medieval Northern Italy there was also a remnant of the Nazarenes called the Pasagini sect, described in a work called *Summa Contra Haereticos*, and it seems that the Pasaginis retained some form of an ante-Nicene Subordinationist high Christology instead of a Co-Equal Trinitarian doctrine.[14] There are also very fringe sects of modern Christians that interpret Paul in a pronomian way, such as the Hebrew Roots & 119 Ministries sects, but it seems that most of them retain the doctrine of co-equal Trinity. My arguments in this document are partially learned from them.[15]

[4] Scholl, Jules-Charles. *L'Islam et son fondateur* (Neuchatel, 1874).
[5] Rösch, Gustav. "Die Jesusmythen des Islam," *Theologische Studien und Kritiken* (1876): 409–454.
[6] von Harnack, Adolf. *Lehrbuch der Dogmengeschichte*, 4th ed. (Tübingen, 1909).
[7] Schlatter, Adolf. "Die Entwicklung des jüdischen Christentums zum Islam," *Evangelisches Missionsmagazin* 62 (1918): 251–264.
[8] Schoeps, Hans-Joachim. *Das Judenchristentum: Untersuchungen über Gruppenbildungen und Parteikämpfe in der frühen Christenheit* (A. Francke AG Verlag, Bern, Switzerland, 1964), tr. Douglas R.H. Hare as *Jewish Christianity: Factional Disputes in the Early Church* (Fortress Press, Philadelphia, 1969).
[9] e.g., Crone, Patricia. "Jewish Christianity and the Qur'ān (Part Two)," *Journal of Near Eastern Studies* 75 (2016): 21.
[10] e.g., Zellentin, Holger. *The Qur'ān's Legal Culture : the Didascalia Apostolorum as a Point of Departure* (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2013).
[11] Tabor, James D. *The Jesus Dynasty: The Hidden History of Jesus, His Royal Family, and the Birth of* Christianity (Simon & Schuster, 2007).
[12] Bütz, Jeffrey J. *The Brother of Jesus and the Lost Teachings of Christianity* (Vermont: Inner Traditions, 2005).
[13] Akyol, Mustafa. *The Islamic Jesus: How the King of the Jews Became a Prophet of the Muslims* (St. Martin's Press, 2017).
[14] Blunt, John Henry. *Dictionary of Sects, Heresies, Ecclesiastical Parties and Schools of Religious Thought.* (London, Oxford & Cambridge: Rivingtons, 1874). pp. 408-9.
[15] e.g., the work by Tim Hegg, David Wilber, Gregory Scott McKenzie.